Crisis of Command

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/32545009.

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General Audiences

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

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She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

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Catra & Glimmer (She-Ra), Catra & Octavia (She-Ra)

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Catra (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra), Octavia (She-Ra), Grizzlor (She-Ra)

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Not Canon Compliant, Alternate Universe - Canon Divergence, Politics, Intrigue

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by EmperorNorton150

Summary

Traitors within the ranks threaten Catra's control over the Horde, forcing her to take drastic action to hold onto power. But is something more sinister lurking behind this plot?

Notes

See the end of the work for notes

Boots slammed against the floor of the Fright Zone's dungeon, a dozen rubber soles slapping against iron plates and concrete slabs. It wasn't an uncommon sound to hear down here, and most of the prisoners slouching behind their forcefields barely glanced up to see if it was their meal coming a little early. Those who did *look* stared, however, eyes following the six guards down the long spiraling corridor until they reached the high-security zone. Two of them flung the burden they'd been dragging through the cell door, then activated the forcefield., Then the whole squad hurried back up the way they'd come, still watched by dozens of wide eyes.

Inside the tiny cell, Catra pulled herself to her feet, winching as her joints flared with pain where the guards had clasped her. Her tail twitching, she tested each limb for functionality, then sat gingerly on the thin cotton pad on the floor. Wrinkling her nose, she brushed at her uniform where they'd ripped the insignia of the Horde and her symbols of rank off.

"*Well*" There was a burst of purple sparks, almost blinding in the darkened cell, and Glimmer appeared next to the Generalissimo. Her arms were crossed and she was scowling. "That went *great*, didn't it?"

"It did actually, thank you" replied Catra, her voice raspy. She spat blood on the floor, then rubbed at her split lip. "Everything is going *exactly* according to my plan."

"Everything?" asked Glimmer, raising an eyebrow. "You know you're still bleeding—oh, just hold *still* for a moment!" Catra squawked as Glimmer wiped at the blood smearing her face with a handkerchief.

"Get off me you lunatic! *Yes*, everything. I know what I'm doing!"

"Uh-huh" muttered Glimmer. "And that's why you're locked in your own dungeon?"

"Exactly" snapped Catra with a flick of her ears. "I told you my plan would be……..unconventional. Give me that!" She grabbed the handkerchief out of Glimmer's hand and dabbed at her face. "All I needed from you is to keep the Princess Alliance from panicking and trying to blow up the Fright Zone while the situation is still so……delicate." Glimmer rolled her eyes, rising to her feet and pacing the narrow cell.

"Oh *sure*, yeah, that'll be easy. 'Hey mom! Catra got thrown in jail and there's a new ruler of the Horde that wants to start the war again and conquer Bright Moon but *don't worry*, she's got it *all* under control!'"

"You said you'd follow my lead, remember? 'Your stupid country, your rules', that's what you said."

"Fine. Fine! Whatever you want. Did you at least find out who the traitor is for sure?"

"Oh yes" murmured Catra, lying down and resting her head on her arms. "Like I said, everything's going exactly according to plan."

ONE HOUR AGO

"……the 63rd and 27th Brigades are now reporting full readiness and should depart for the frontier on schedule. The training cadres for the 103rd and 105th Divisions have reported to the Fright Zone and should begin basic training within the week, as soon as the rest of their supplies arrives……" the Council Recorder's voice was a dull drone, cutting through the humid air of the meeting chamber. The air conditioning was broken. Again. And after a two-hour session of the Command Council, the Force Captains were starting to list in their chairs, eyes glazed over in boredom. "……ration bar production is above quota by 20% in the Fright Zone, Hordeopolis, and Colonia, but down by 5% in the Eastern Hills and Octopus Cove…….a select committee has been empaneled to investigate the disparity…….textile production has

increased by 10% across the board despite the weevil infestations in the Southern Swamps…….initial feedback on the new market pilot project has been highly enthusiastic, but no report can be produced until the end of the quarter." The Recorder tapped her sheaf of papers against the desk and coughed. "I believe that concludes this month's production summary." Catra stirred from her slump, fur bristling as she shook herself back to full awareness.

"Thank you as always for that……exhaustive report" the Generalissimo said smoothly.

"Thank Hordak it's done" growled Force Captain Grizzlor under his breath. Catra frowned at him.

"Does anyone else have any business to bring before the Council?" she asked. There was a low murmur as her commanders shook their heads (or other appendages, depending on species) or otherwise signaled *no*. It was a quiet, for a full meeting of the Command Council. Lonnie and Rogelio were in Octopus Cove, putting together the next invasion fleet to deal with the Snake-Men, Scorpia was in Fort Drakon, inspecting border defenses, and half-a-dozen other Force Captains were absent on various other errands. Some of them she'd dispatched herself. Some of the absences were more—more surprising.

"Well then! If that's all—" buzzed Mosquitor, rising to his feet with a flick of his wings. Catra held up a claw.

"Ah! No, actually, I did have one more *small* matter to discuss." A chorus of muffled groans filled the room. Her ears flicked, and she grinned out at the room, fangs bared. "One of you is a traitor……and I know *who*."

"What?!"

"That's outrageous!"

"I knew it! I always suspected *you*!"

"How dare you accuse me?! I mean, uh, accuse whoever you're accusing. It's not me!"

"I'll tear him limb from limb Your Excellency!" Catra sat silently through the cacophony. Her eyes swept across the table and—and locked with those of Force Captain Cyrus. The thin, almost skeletal man with a perfectly-coiffured head of dark hair nodded, and rose to his feet.

"Comrades. Comrades! Please, settle down. I believe I know who our *dear leader* is referring to."

"It's you!" roared Grizzlor, pounding his fist on the tabletop. "You're the traitor!"

"You mean you're *not* one?" asked Catra.

"No!" bellowed the ursine Force Captain.

"Huh" said Catra. "Well, keep up the good work. Yes, our *dear* comrade-in-arms Cyrus is the one who leaked word of our attack on the Snake-Men to King Hiss. He's also been feeding intelligence on our operations to……someone. Not to mention embezzlement, theft of supplies, and trying to suborn his fellow officers."

"Nothing that you didn't do before your ascension Your Excellency" murmured Cyrus. Catra nodded.

"That's true. The difference is, I *won*."

"And you think I won't?" Cyrus sneered. "Comrades, if trying to *save* the Horde from this madwoman is treason, then call me a traitor! Since she's taken control she has betrayed every principle Hordak laid down, sold out every *one* of us to the Princess Alliance in exchange for trinkets and personal gain!" He waved his arm dramatically, pointing an accusatory finger at the Generalissimo, who merely cocked her head and listened. "She's unfit, incapable, incompetent, and weak, and she is leading the Horde to disaster. If not for her, we would rule all of Etheria

instead huddling here in the Fright Zone prattling about *ration bars* and *textile quotas*!" Catra laughed.

"You morons spent the last fifty years trying to defeat some trees and you think I'm the reason you couldn't win the war?"

"We would have won years ago if not for weaklings and traitors undermining us from within!"

"Oh, come on!" Catra sniffed. "I know you're not *actually* that stupid Cyrus, stop pretending."

"I speak only the truth, and I only wish what is best for my beloved Horde—"

"Your Excellency" broke in Force Captain Callix, his gravely voice rumbling. "There is no reason for us to listen to this pathetic mewling. Please put a stop to this nonsense." Catra nodded at him.

"Agreed" she said, tapping a button on the table next to her. The doors slammed open, and two dozen Horde troopers poured in, clutching laser rifles and shock-sticks. One by one, they lined up behind Cyrus, aiming their weapons across the room. Following them in strode former Force Captain Octavia, dressed in a new, insignia-less uniform. She fell into parade rest behind Cyrus, and the treacherous Force Captain smirked as a murmur of shock ran around the table. Several Force Captains slapped at their com badges, only to be met with shrieks of jamming static, while three of their fellows—*nonentities, one and all*—Catra automatically classified them, rose from their seats and scurried to stand behind Cyrus.

"Ah" said Catra, resting her chin on the palm of her hand and sighing. "That's unfortunate. Shouldn't you be in jail?" She directed the latter question at Octavia, whose remaining eye glinted with rage.

"I have friends, friends in high places you never knew about" she rasped. "Now we're going to make you pay for betraying Hordak."

"Are you really still upset about me overthrowing that old fool? You're more pathetic than I thought."

"As you can see *Your Excellency*, the Horde has already made its decision," broke in Cyrus with a scowl. "Why, even the lowliest trooper can see that your weak-willed policies can only lead the Horde into ruin. Only under the hand of a *true* disciple of Hordak can we rise again to greatness, to glory, to our destiny, and with loyal soldiers like Octavia at my side, I shall—what are you *doing*?!" Catra had laid her head back on the back of her chair and closed her eyes.

"Taking a nap" she said without moving. "If you're just going to keep talking than I'm going to get some rest in before all the executions and arrests and proscriptions begin." Cyrus's face darkened.

"My *apologies*" he snarled. "Let's get started then." He waved, and half of his suborned troops moved forward towards Catra. As they passed Force Captain Callix, he turned and slammed his granite fist into one of their chests. The soldier flopped over without a sound, and Callix swung his arm at the others. They leapt back, but the massive Force Captain moved with a speed belied by his size, grabbing one of the troops by the front of her uniform and dragging her in close. Other soldiers pulsed stun-blasts at him, but he effortlessly hoisted his struggling captive into the air as a shield, then tossed her into her fellows, knocking two of them off their feet.

"Death to all traitors!" roared Grizzlor, hurling himself onto the tabletop and bounding towards Cyrus on all fours. Stun blasts pulsed over his armor, slowing but not stopping him, and Mosquitor took advantage of the chaos to leap into the air and throw himself out of a window, wings buzzing as he dodged a pair of laser blasts. Callix ripped a quarterstaff out of the hands of yet

another soldier, knocking them in the head with it and whirling to face Cyrus too—then there was a burst of red-black fire and the Force Captain went flying back, scorch marks on his chest. A second burst of sparks flashed, and Grizzlor crashed onto the tabletop, fur smoking, stunned. Cyrus stood with his hand outstretched. On his finger glinted a golden ring set with a blood-red gemstone. Sparks crackled around it.

"I rule the Horde!" he screamed. *Enough of this* thought Catra. She leapt for the ceiling from a sitting start, powerful leg muscles propelling her into the air. Her arms popped open the maintenance panel and grabbed hold, and she was starting to swing the rest of her body inside when there was another burst of light. Pain crackled up and down her nerves, and everything went black.

"My tutors say that a country is like a crystal" said Glimmer. Catra raised an eyebrow.

"A crystal?" she asked. She was still sprawled on the thin pad that served as a bed for prisoners, head propped up on her crossed arms. Glimmer was on the opposite side of the cell—which meant she was just a few feet away, leaning against the metal wall.

"Yeah!" said Glimmer. She framed a diamond shape in the air with her hands. "You know, all the different facets of a society—farmers, merchants, soldiers, knights, scholars, rulers—interlocked together in a single structure, each supporting the others in an endless chain, fitting together into a shining whole."

"Is that a quote?"

"Erasmus dy Vondelbaert, *The Government & Society of Etheria*" said Glimmer primly.

"Well, it's stupid."

"You're calling the greatest political ethicist in Bright Moon's history stupid?"

"Yes. A country's like a machine." Glimmer leaned back and frowned as Catra continued. "It's all spinning wheels and pistons and gears, all hammering at each other all the time, smashing and howling. It needs to be feed, it needs to be oiled, it needs to be cleaned, and everything has to be kept in perfect balance. Make one mistake and the forces you're generating will rip you apart."

"That's a bit bleak, no?" Catra flicked her ears.

"Let's take a look at what happens to this perfect, shining diamond of yours if we hit it. Hmmmm, let's say there's a drought next year. The rains don't come and the crops fail all across your kingdom. The farmers don't have enough food to sell in the markets, so they hoard what they have. Food prices in town rocket up, and the merchants and artisans start to go hungry. You send out your tax collectors, and nobody can afford to pay. Maybe you say 'Ok! Amnesty for all!' Then your coffers empty out, your army dissolves for lack of pay, and when the townspeople and the peasants start killing each other over what's left of the food, you won't be able to do anything. Then your neighbors roll in and conquer you. Or, maybe you send out your tax collectors anyways, collect tribute at the point of a sword. Then your people start shooting at you, your army starts burning villages after the first few ambushes, and your neighbors roll in and conquer you. That's why the lands around the Boiling Sea have part of the Horde for the last thirty years. One slip, and the machine tears itself to pieces." Catra's claws tapped the floor in emphasis.

"Oh, so what am I supposed to do then?" snapped Glimmer. "Kill everyone in Bright Moon the second anything goes wrong?" Catra's ears flattened.

"I was going to suggest keeping stockpiles of grain in case of famine" she said drily. "Something that Bright Moon has

done for the last two and a half centuries." Glimmer flushed and looked away.

"Sorry" she muttered. Catra waved it away.

"Don't worry about it" she growled. Glimmer sighed and plopped to the cell floor, grimacing at the sticky pull of it on her skin.

"It's been three hours" she announced. "We're really just going to sit here and discuss political theory while the Horde falls apart upstairs?"

"Hey, *you* asked *me* to teach you about politics" said Catra, flicking her ears resentfully. "And now you're complaining about it?"

"I asked you for advice because I assumed you were *good* at this junk! Isn't the first rule of politics to *not* lose control of your country?"

"Correct" Glimmer flung her hands in the air.

"Then what are we doing here?!"

"Waiting"

"For what?!"

"You'll see."

"ARRRGHHHH!" Glimmer shouted. "Lost Stars, why don't I just go and tell Adora you need a little help? She could punch out that Cyrus guy in five minutes and then—" Catra's hand shot out like a striking snake, grabbing Glimmer's arm.

"Don't you *dare*" she snarled.

"I won't!" said Glimmer, yanking her arm away. "I promised, didn't I?"

"Good" growled Catra. Glimmer sighed and shook her head.

"Why……why does that upset you so much?" Catra shrugged.

"I don't need Adora's help for *anything*" she grumbled, flopping her head back down again. "And I'm *not* gonna let her control my life anymore." Glimmer looked at the other girl curiously. Since she'd started working together with Catra, they'd faced down murderous monarchs, treacherous diplomats, bureaucratic inertia, and more than one literal man-eating monster. And yet, the only thing that ever seemed to break through Catra's shell of ironic distance was the mention of Adora. It was *really* starting to get on her nerves. Glimmer was a very straightforward person. You either loved someone or you hated them. People were either your friends or your enemies. This whole……thing between Adora and Catra made her uncomfortable, and it had gotten worse since she and Catra had become…….well, not *friends* exactly but colleagues of a sort. People who cared about each other. Well, at least *she* cared about the little fuzzball, stars alone knew what *Catra* thought about her.

"I thought you two were talking to each other again" she said finally. "Are you *really* still holding a grudge over whatever it was you think she did to you?"

"We are" Catra said softly. "And I'm not……I'm not holding a grudge! I just don't want her trying to run my life anymore. Yes, I *know*—" she preempted Glimmer before she could respond. "She just wants to help. So what? You let people help you too much and you rely on them. You rely on them and then one day.....they're not there when you need them. Lesson in politics right there for you sparkles. Remember that."

"Um" said Glimmer, trying to pick her words carefully. "I'm not sure about that. I mean, that's kind of the opposite of how we think about things in the Princess Alliance. We each help each other, and that way we make each stronger."

"What" scoffed Catra "like a beautiful crystal?"

"Hey, Hordak spent decades trying to conquer us and failed!"

"Oh, like beating *Hordak* is impressive. You could do that in your sleep."

"We beat you too! At least, sometimes we did." Catra flicked her ears.

"That *is* a point" she admitted. "But I would've beat you eventually if I really wanted to."

"In your dreams Horde Scum! But that's not the point. The point is….being in charge doesn't mean being alone. Or at least, it doesn't have to be. If people wanna help you, maybe you should let them. There, that's *my* lesson for you."

"I'll……I'll think about it" the other girl said finally, her tail lashing.

"Catra—"

"I said I'll think about it, ok? Now why don't you make yourself useful and do another scouting run." Glimmer rolled her eyes.

"Whatever you say *Your Excellency*." The Princess of Bright Moon vanished in a puff of flickering sparks, reappeared in a maintenance closet on the fifth level of the main command citadel, reoriented, then teleported again to the tiny, disused observation platform on top of an old derrick that Catra had told her about. Glimmer had been to the Fright Zone enough times over the last few years to get a feel for what it looked like normally. This was not that. The parade grounds and passageways were empty, except for the occasional small band of furtive individuals, scuttling back and forth. Even as she watched, two groups of troops ran into each other and began gesticulating wildly. Quickly, someone threw a punch and a brawl developed.

The furnaces and manufactories were dark and empty, with no fumes emerging from their smokestacks, but a dense column of black smoke was pouring out of one of the bastions on the eastern perimeter, and a number of the gun batteries stood motionless, barrels pointing at the darkened sky. Something flickered on the distant horizon, and she squinted. The Eastern Highway was alive with motion. Tanks, bots, and skimmers, rapidly rolling towards the Fright Zone, escorting a long column of trucks. She whistled, and teleported back to the dungeon to report in to Catra.

The Generalissimo listened intently, then chuckled.

"Shouldn't be long now" she announced. "You better go hide in an air shaft or an empty cell or something."

"Alright" said Glimmer dubiously. "Sing out if you need help, *ok*?"

"Sure thing princess." Glimmer stuck out her tongue and vanished with a gentle *pop*. Catra leaned back and grinned predatorily at the ceiling of her cell.

Boots slammed against the floor of the Fright Zone's dungeon, a dozen rubber soles slapping against iron plates and concrete slabs. Catra didn't open her eyes, even as the clatter grew louder and louder. Finally, it stopped. Someone coughed peremptorily. She stretched and rolled over with a flick of her tail.

"How are you enjoying your new accommodations?" She blinked and looked up. Cyrus, wearing a new green-and-black uniform clearly patterned after Hodak's old suit of armor, stood in front of her cell forcefield, hands on his hips. Octavia was with him, as well as two nervous-looking Force Captains and a squad of troops. She shrugged.

"They're ok" she said, waggling a hand. "It's not the first time I've been in one of these cells, won't be the last. I *am*

glad I had conditions down here overhauled last year though. All that mildew and bugs? Ugh. No thanks."

"That was rather an improvement" noted Octavia, her tentacles shivering in amusement. "I suppose I should thank you for that."

"Glad to be appreciated" purred Catra.

"Well then," said Cyrus. "If you are so satisfied with the new arrangement, surely you won't object to…..providing some assistance to the Hode's new leadership?" Catra chuckled.

"Cyrus, Cyrus, *Cyrus*. Less than a day in, and you're already asking me for help? Are you sure you're cut out for this job?"

"I do not *require* your help!" snapped the dark-haired man. His hands shook, and he took a deep breath. "I have come —in the spirit of mercy—to offer you a way you can still, hmmm, make yourself useful, let us say."

"Oh?"

"I wish for you to record a message for immediate broadcast, calling on all Horde forces to recognize me as their new Overlord and Supreme Commander."

"I see. Having some trouble with keeping the troops in line I take it?"

"There are a few…..small holdouts" he admitted. "Nothing I can't handle. But this would allow us to resolve the situation with less bloodshed." He knelt down, hand outstretched towards the cell. Behind him, Octavia sneered. "Catra, despite our differences, I *truly* believe that you really care about what happens here. Recognize the inevitable, and help me return stability and unity to the Horde. You'll be saving lives and helping to lay the foundation for the Horde's return to victory! *And*, cooperation will, hmmm, have a favorable impact on your final

disposition." Catra pulled herself into a sitting position, then onto her feet. She paced over to the forcefield, her tail twitching. She shook her head.

"I'm a little surprised" she said. "Honestly, I expected to be down here *at least* a day or two before you realized you were in over your head."

"I *told* you, everything is under control—"

"Shut up" said Catra, a *snap* of command in her voice. "I'm going to tell you what's been happening for the last few hours. After your little performance in the Council Chamber, you sent out a proclamation announcing yourself as the new ruler of the Horde. But most of the other cities and outposts haven't responded, or if they have, they're playing it safe. Not committing to anything, trying to sound you out. You give orders—and sometimes they're followed. But sometimes not. Sometimes you send a messenger and they just—vanish. The Force Captains and District Commanders are mobilizing, but they're not listening to you, and the workers are hiding under their forges in case everything falls apart again."

"Not everyone is eager to recognize their new master" grumbled Cyrus, a wary look in his eye. "They'll come around soon enough."

"The longer it takes for you to exert authority, the harder it becomes" continued Catra. Her eyes bored in Cyrus, and her tail flicked like a metronome. "The Horde respects *strength*, not platitudes. If people think you're not capable of holding the top job, they'll try for it themselves. And you don't *have* strength Cyrus, not enough of it. Two-thirds of the military is stationed along the frontier you moron. Do you think those officers care you that you sorta control the Fright Zone?" There was a muted *roar* in the distance, and the structure of the Horde prison shivered slightly. Further explosions rattled, as artillery opened fire. Catra grinned. "Ah! It's beginning. I suspect that's Scorpia's troops" she added conversationally. "Fort Drakon's not far from here, and she's

always been a punctual woman. But give it time. Lonnie ought to be here in a few hours." Cyrus's face darkened, and he barked an order at one of his men, who saluted and dashed back up the corridor.

"Order her to retreat!" he barked at the prisoner. "Order your people to surrender if you want to live!" Catra shook her head.

"You really are an idiot, you know that? If I do that, all it will do is tell everyone that *I'm* no longer to be respected. The Force Captains still loyal to me will start looking out for themselves, and the Horde will fall apart. Faster than it already is, I should say. Do you understand that it took me *three years* before I was ready to move against Hordak for a *reason?* You can't just put on a fancy hat and declare yourself king!"

"If you're so smart" hissed Cyrus "then why are *you* in there while *I'm* out here?" Catra grinned.

"Because the easiest way to see who was part of your stupid little conspiracy was to let you try and pull it off." Cyrus stared, his eyes widening. Without a word, Octavia took a step forward and punched the release code in for the cell. As the forcefield flickered and vanished, she turned, drew a shock-stick, and zapped the two other Force Captains. Cyrus roared incoherently and raised his hand, bathing the inside of the cell with red-black fire, but Catra was already diving past him, slamming into a guard. She knocked him unconscious with a blow to the head, yanked his knife from his belt, and got it up just in time to parry a swinging quarterstaff blow from another soldier. She rolled, hopped to her feet, and ducked again, dodging the staff. Octavia was backed up against a wall, laughing wildly as three more guards tried to corner her. Catra lashed out with her knife and dove it into the whirling quarterstaff, shattering both weapons and sending the soldier toppling to the ground. Catra rolled again, kicked while she was down, and then leapt into the air to avoid another blast of fire from Cyrus's ring.

"Traitors! All of you are traitors!" bellowed Cyrus. Catra laughed.

"You started it, remember? Whoops! Missed again!" she caught ahold of a pipe and flung herself around, feeling the *tingle* of electricity as the sparks singed her fur. Octavia had dispatched two of her opponents by now, but the third—the squad sergeant—was holding her own, using a pair of short swords to keep the former admiral at bay. Catra ducked two more blasts of fire, looking for an opening to punch through, when the world seemed to *lurch* underneath her. Cyrus had gotten bored of trying to track her, and had sent a tendril of fire to rip open the pipe down its length. Catra yowled as hot steam poured out, scalding her fur, and she crashing to the ground. She whirled, already trying to make another leap, but her injured legs gave out under her, and she smashed back into the floor. She could see Cyrus's grinning face, see the ring rising towards her—when Glimmer appeared in midair, heralded by purple sparks.

"Stay away from her!" the Princess screamed, kicking Cyrus in the face. The treacherous Force Captain went down hard. He tried to rise—then yelped as Octavia zapped him with a shock stick, and crashed back down again, unconscious.

"That was fun" said Catra, climbing to her feet with a wince. She nodded at Glimmer, who scowled at her.

"*That* was your plan? Let him take over your stupid country and then try and beat him up?"

"Pretty much" said Catra with a flick of her ears. She knelt by Cyrus, pulling off his com badge. Gingerly, she pulled the ring from his finger and sniffed it. She hissed, her hackles rising, and threw it down the hallway. They could hear it *plink-plink-plinking* away into the darkness. "Scorpia figured out *weeks* ago that he'd been sending encoded transmissions out and receiving instructions from someone. All I had to do was leak that I was closing in on him, plant a double-agent in his clique" she nodded at Octavia "and wait for him to strike. This way, I let him draw out

of his supporters into the open instead of having to try and dig them out. *And*, I showed the Horde the kind of chaos that'll happen if they lose me. Should help bring some of the waverers around."

"That's the stupidest thing I ever heard!" shouted Glimmer.

"It worked, didn't it?" said Catra. "Thanks for the help, by the way." She turned to Octavia. "You too."

"So, do I get my job back then?" growled the other woman. "I fulfilled my half of the bargain."

"Of course, *Fleet Captain* Octavia. I always keep my promises." There was a clatter of footsteps, and another squad of troops burst into the hallway. Their lieutenant looked down at Cyrus lying on the floor, looked up at Catra, and saluted.

"Command us Your Excellency!" he barked. The Generalissimo grinned.

"Smart boy" she commented. "Send someone to order the perimeter defenses to stop firing. Release anyone else this traitor locked up, and stand by to receive a transmission from Princess Entrapta. It'll contain a list of people to place under immediate arrest. And get *him*" she tapped Cyrus with her toe "to an interrogation chamber." Catra looked down the hallway to where his ring glinted on the metal floor and all the warmth drained from her face. "I want to know what he's been saying to Shadow Weaver."

End Notes

- Following up on some threads from "Fire on the Mountain" and "The Honor of the Horde" and setting up some stuff to come. Ongoing plots! What won't they think of next?

- If it hasn't been clear, in this timeline Shadow Weaver left the Horde at the same time but vanished and hasn't been seen since.

- All of the other Force Captains except Cyrus are from the 1985 show.

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!